to obtain some of its lands in exchange for access to valuable trade items from Europe.

England and Portugal were not the only European nations from which travelers and traders came to India. In the early 17th century, Dutch, French, and Danish merchants established their own trade routes between home and India and set up their own depots and factories. With so many commercially minded Europeans coming onto the scene, Indian producers quickly realized that they could start charging more for in-demand supplies like silk, cotton, cinnamon, and cardamom. When the prices went up, the British knew the only way to knock costs back down was to get rid of the competition.

Though British occupation in India was at first intended solely for commercial purposes, the company was almost immediately militarized against the other foreign trading communities in the area. Soldiers regularly fought against the encroaching forces of their Dutch and Portuguese rivals while also using the sword to gain control over more land. In true European fashion, the separate entities started fortifying their trading posts with stone walls. The infighting came to a breaking point just a few decades later when local administrators and rulers also became involved in the skirmishes. Such behavior characterized most of the 17th century.

A century later, these nations had inextricably embedded themselves in the Indian landscape, capitalizing on the slow downfall of the Mughal Empire. With the local regimes crumbling, British soldiers were dispatched to India to defend their commercial lands against various armies vying for control of the subcontinent. Successful in its bid to maintain Indian territory, the company itself made the quite unprecedented decision to fight for even more land. Also using the opportunity of political unrest to their gain, the Netherlands, Portugal, France, and Denmark fought for their own territory.

In an attempt to settle things amicably with the powers that be, in 1698, the EIC bribed Mughal officials for zamindari rights over three villages in Bengal—that is, the same type of rights held by aristocrats and lords over their appointed tracts of land. Practicing careful diplomacy, they were even granted a farman (similar to a royal charter) from Emperor Aurangzeb. Those villages were called Sutanuti, Gobindapur, and Kalikata; they eventually grew into the modern city of Kolkata, formerly known as Calcutta.